Husain Quli gave him his own canteen. When the time for his execution came, the sultan was as unwilling to part with his head as with his pride: the Mughal men ‘took two chops at his neck without success’, writes Badauni, before ‘they succeeded in killing him’.

So fell the Bengal sultanate. Its last sultan’s head was ‘stuffed . . . with straw, and anointed . . . with perfumes’, and given to one Sayyid Abdullah Khan, to take to Akbar.

The messenger and his prize arrived just in time. Daud had been creating such a ruckus that Akbar had decided to go east once again, but had only just left Fatehpur when he had one of his new visions: news of victory would soon arrive. Indeed, he was still on the outskirts of Agra when Abdullah Khan came bearing Daud’s head, and, in an indignity that the dead sultan couldn’t prevent, threw it into a shed.

Akbar was delighted at news of Daud’s defeat. As a reward, he had such quantities of gold poured into Abdullah Khan’s lap, the messenger couldn’t pick it all up.

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The Anup Talao overflowing with coins, the messenger’s lap heaped with gold – Akbar had come a long way from the young ruler whose attendants scrambled for 17 rupees in an echoing treasury. It was only a little before Abdullah Khan that Badauni, too, had arrived bearing news from a battlefield – in his case, Haldighati – and he presents a scene of Akbar disbursing largesse that is the spitting image, if not the genesis, of the stereotypical oriental despot and his pots of gold. ‘The Emperor was exceedingly pleased,’ writes Badauni, both at news of the battle and because Badauni had brought Rana Pratap’s grand elephant, Ram Prasad, along with him. To reward the messenger, Akbar reached into ‘a heap of Ashrafis (which in those days, just like a heap in a treasury, used always to be laid before him)’ and gave him ninety-six gold coins.[13]

For all the magnificent display of excess, Akbar’s munificence was neither profligate nor unplanned. Almost as frequent as battles in the *Akbarnama* are scenes of Akbar in consultation with the men who calculated his revenues, planned the assessments of his lands, and, in sum, turned conquest to profit. As Abul Fazl would put it, ‘the care of property, and the